

Impacts of Citizens' Assemblies

What We Know • Research brief • January 2026

This research brief presents a summary of the literature on the impacts of citizens' assemblies (CAs). We reviewed and synthesized nearly 70 studies into 19 key findings organized by their impacts on individuals, communities, and governments.

How to use this brief

Our goal is to provide a succinct and informative summary that practitioners, civil servants, and researchers can use to meet their needs, including for advocacy and promotion of CAs in their communities, for designing and implementing CAs that use evidence-informed best practices, or to identify gaps in knowledge that further research could address. To this end, we provide practical recommendations drawn from the literature on advocacy; planning and design; as well as research, monitoring and evaluation.



This document is based on findings and recommendations compiled by Ryan Gem and Maria Milosh, with instrumental help from People Powered's Research Committee.

How we created this brief

To synthesize the key findings in this research brief, we scanned the literature using keyword searches of academic databases combined with backward and forward snowball sampling. We defined citizens' assemblies as a deliberative body made up primarily of regular citizens selected through sortition (also called a lottery system or random selection) with a mandate to deliberate and make recommendations on at least one policy issue.

We did not discriminate based on the size of the deliberative body or whether it was tasked with making a non-binding policy recommendation (*recommendational*) or had secured commitments from government actors to uphold the CA's conclusions (*decisional*), so long as they used sortition as the selection method. We therefore considered research on minipublics, citizen juries, deliberative bodies, climate assemblies, and citizens assemblies. We ultimately included nearly 70 peer-reviewed papers, reports, and book chapters that met this criteria.

Limitations

While over 700 CAs have been convened in the last two decades, the majority were in European Union countries and almost all of the studies focus on European cases. Though this brief includes findings from Asia, Latin America, and Africa, they are a minority of the cases covered. There is a need to expand studies of CAs beyond Europe, to ensure that the findings hold true in other contexts. Relatedly, there may be a need to modify the design and implementation of CAs to be more feasible in more resource-constrained settings, such as relaxing the random selection requirement, since this approach can make CAs more costly to administer (see Annunziata 2025 for more on this point)

Though the concept has existed since Ancient Greece, modern citizens' assemblies are a relatively recent democratic innovation. As a result, very little longitudinal evidence is available, meaning we do not yet know the long-term impacts of citizens' assemblies. There is also relatively little causal research in this field. Both are much needed areas for further research, which could help strengthen the case for citizens' assemblies and help us to understand where and how they are most impactful.



Key Findings: What We Know

Impacts on People

Finding 1: CAs increase political knowledge and efficacy

- **Canada, the Netherlands, Poland, Scotland, and Germany:** Participation in CAs increased political knowledge, interest, and feelings of efficacy. (Fournier et al. 2011; Paulis & Pospieszna 2024; Elstub et al. 2022; Wappenhans et al. 2024)
- **California (USA):** Assembly participants demonstrated more knowledge and a better understanding of political issues and government decision making. (Ehsassi 2023)
- **Belgrade (Serbia):** CA participation had a positive impact on participants' knowledge of the assembly topic, political awareness, and interest in political processes. (Đorđević & Vasiljević; Janković 2022)
- **Spain:** Those who participated in a national climate assembly reported gaining new knowledge and skills that bolstered their perceptions of their own political efficacy. (Fernández-Martínez & Bates 2023)
- **Mar del Plata (Argentina) and Buenaventura (Colombia):** Surveys found that participation in local climate assemblies led to increased knowledge of both climate change and deliberative processes and a greater belief that policy interventions to address the problem were possible. (Annunziata 2025)
- **Yukon and Victoria-Saanich (Canada):** Participants in CAs greatly increased their knowledge on the CA topics, including by voluntarily spending time outside of the assembly educating themselves on the issue. (Hurner 202 Brackenbury 2025)
- A meta-analysis of 100 studies published between 1980-2020 found consistent evidence that participation in CAs increases the knowledge, internal efficacy, and reasoning skills of participants. (Theuwis, Jacobs, & Van Ham 2025)

Practical Recommendations

Planning & Design:

- Include structured learning components (such as expert briefings and Q&A sessions) and ensure time for reflection and discussion to magnify these positive effects.
- While dividing participants into smaller groups for discussion can be helpful at some points in the process, avoid dividing participants into topic areas since this can compromise breadth of learning for participants and lead to less informed collective decision making (Elstub, Carrick, Farrell, and Mockler 2021).



Impacts on People

Finding 2: CAs increase political engagement and participation

- **Spain and France:** National Climate Assembly members reported greater confidence, public-speaking skills, and political efficacy, with many becoming more active in politics or community life after the process. (Fernández-Martínez & Bates 2023; Mellier & Tilikete 2025)
- **United States:** A national field experiment found lasting effects a year after a CA was convened: participants were more likely to vote and follow elections, especially women and less educated groups. (Fishkin et al. 2024)
- **Canada and Poland:** A survey experiment and case study, respectively, found short-term gains in political interest levels and willingness to express opinions among non-participants exposed to assemblies and greater openness to citizen input among public officials (Boulianne 2018b; Ross 2022)
- **Germany:** Field experiments in six electoral districts found participation in CAs led to higher trust and increased willingness to take part in politics after the process concluded. (Wappenhans et al. 2024)
- **Yukon (Canada):** Participants reported engaging in more political discussions, watching the news and volunteering in their communities more frequently after the CA. (Hurner 2024)
- **Scotland:** After participating in a national climate assembly around half of the participants reported being inspired to become more involved in government decision making on climate change, with two participants even running for elected positions in the hope of influencing decisions about climate change. (Andrews et al. 2022)

Planning & Design:

- Provide follow-up opportunities for participants such as alumni networks, civic education opportunities or civic action toolkits to increase and prolong these positive effects.

Research, Monitoring & Evaluation:

- Track participants' political engagement and participation at regular intervals to determine the longevity of these effects.



Impacts on People

Finding 3: CAs reduce polarization and increase openness to opposing views

- **United States:** Participants in a national field experiment simulating a CA became less polarized on 22 out of 26 policy topics and showed lower emotional hostility between political parties after the process. (Fishkin et al. 2021)
- **Ireland:** Participation in a national CA led to more moderate and reflective opinions even on a highly polarizing policy topic like abortion. (Farrell et al. 2020)
- **Oregon and Connecticut (USA):** Survey experiments found that participation in simulated CAs helps people rethink their preferences and adopt more moderate policy positions, these effects are strongest on less salient issues that people previously knew little about. (Farrar et al. 2010; Ingham & Levin 2017)
- **Gyeonggi Province (South Korea):** Deliberation through CAs appeared to weaken the influence of material self-interests on policy preferences, making people more open to policies that did not directly serve their own interests. (Jaeho 2024)
- **Yukon (Canada):** 76% of CA participants that answered the final survey reported feeling that there was reduced polarization and division in their community. (Hurner 2024)



Advocacy:

- Frame CAs as tools for democratic healing in polarized societies.



Planning & Design:

- Use skilled facilitators to manage disagreement constructively.



Research, Monitoring & Evaluation:

- Investigate which CA designs are most effective at reducing affective and ideological polarization.



Citizens' assembly on dangerous heat waves in India (MHT)



Impacts on People

Finding 4: CAs foster internal political efficacy and trust in others

- **Canada and the Netherlands:** CA participants expressed an increased sense of political efficacy and became more positive toward and trusting of their fellow citizens. (Fournier et al. 2011)
- **Germany:** Participation in CAs had positive effects on political efficacy, political participation, and trust in others. (Wappenhans et al. 2024)
- **Oregon (USA):** Those who read summaries of a CA's findings reported feeling increased internal political efficacy and more belief in the capabilities of their fellow citizens to govern. (Knobloch, Gastil, & Barthel 2019)
- **United States:** Those who participated in a national field experiment simulating a CA became more likely to vote in subsequent elections and to believe their political opinions mattered, these effects persisted for at least a year. (Fishkin et al. 2024)

Advocacy:

- Promote CAs as an effective means of (re)building social trust.

Planning & Design:

- Use small-group formats to help encourage equal participation and mutual respect, but avoid siloing groups by topic areas.

Research, Monitoring & Evaluation:

- Explore how trust-building effects of CAs vary across cultural and political contexts.

Finding 5: CAs can shift attitudes on specific issues

- **Tanzania:** A national experiment found that deliberation led citizens to favor social spending over infrastructure development or cash transfers, aligning their views more closely with expert opinion. (Sandefur et al. 2022)
- **Connecticut (USA):** A survey experiment found that discussion helps people refine and moderate their preferences, especially on issues they had thought about less before. (Farrar et al. 2010)
- **Nairobi (Kenya):** Group deliberation produced fairer and more widely supported collective choices, with participants reporting shifts in preferences and stronger agreement with outcomes. (Grillos 2021)
- **Ireland:** Citizens and politicians that participated in an assembly ended up with similar views on social and moral issues, including abortion. (Farrell et al. 2020a, 2020b)
- **Yukon and Victoria-Saanich (Canada):** A majority of participants in regional CAs reported that their opinion on the policy topics debated changed and evolved throughout the process. (Hurner 2024; Brackenbury 2025)
- **Scotland:** Regular surveys of participants in a national level CA showed that members of all demographics were open to changing their policy preferences when presented with new information. For example, after learning about public spending the percent of participants who supported increasing taxes rose from 44% to 73%. (Elstub et al. 2022)

Advocacy:

- Emphasize to policymakers that participating in CAs can foster positive feelings toward government, including an openness to increased taxation.

Planning & Design:

- Present balanced, evidence-based information on the issues under consideration and ensure exposure to diverse perspectives.
- Be mindful of how topics are framed to CA members. Overly narrow or technical framing of issues can shut down debate on more ambitious or transformative policy solutions (Zeitfogel, Daw, & Collste 2025)

Impacts on People

Finding 6: CAs can increase satisfaction with democracy and trust in government, but this effect decreases over time

- **Canada, the Netherlands, and Poland:** Participation in CAs increased feelings of political efficacy, satisfaction with democracy, and trust of fellow citizens, but these improvements varied by context and group. (Fournier et al. 2011; Hurner 2024; Paulis & Pospieszna 2024)
- **Edmonton (Canada) and the United States:** Participation in CAs tend to increase trust in government and feelings of political efficacy, but follow-up surveys find that long-term effects are mixed with some participants becoming more trusting and engaged, while others show little change after the process ends. (Boulianne 2018a; Minozzi et al. 2023)

Research, Monitoring & Evaluation:

- Study how these gains in political trust decline over time and what types of institutional responses, such as follow-up measures or implementation, sustain trust.

Finding 7: CAs can reduce populist attitudes and conspiracy thinking under some circumstances

- **The Netherlands:** Participants who entered a CA with populist views became less populist after the assembly. (Jacobs 2024)
- **Canada and the Netherlands:** In other studies, populist attitudes remained unchanged after participating in CAs. (Fournier et al. 2011)
- **Germany:** Participation in CAs seemed to diminish conspiracy mentalities, but only when they included representatives from multiple different political parties. (Wappenhans et al. 2024)

Advocacy:

- Promote CAs as potential antidotes to political alienation, polarization, and misinformation.

Planning & Design:

- Include multiparty political actors and transparent processes to build credibility.



Impacts on Communities

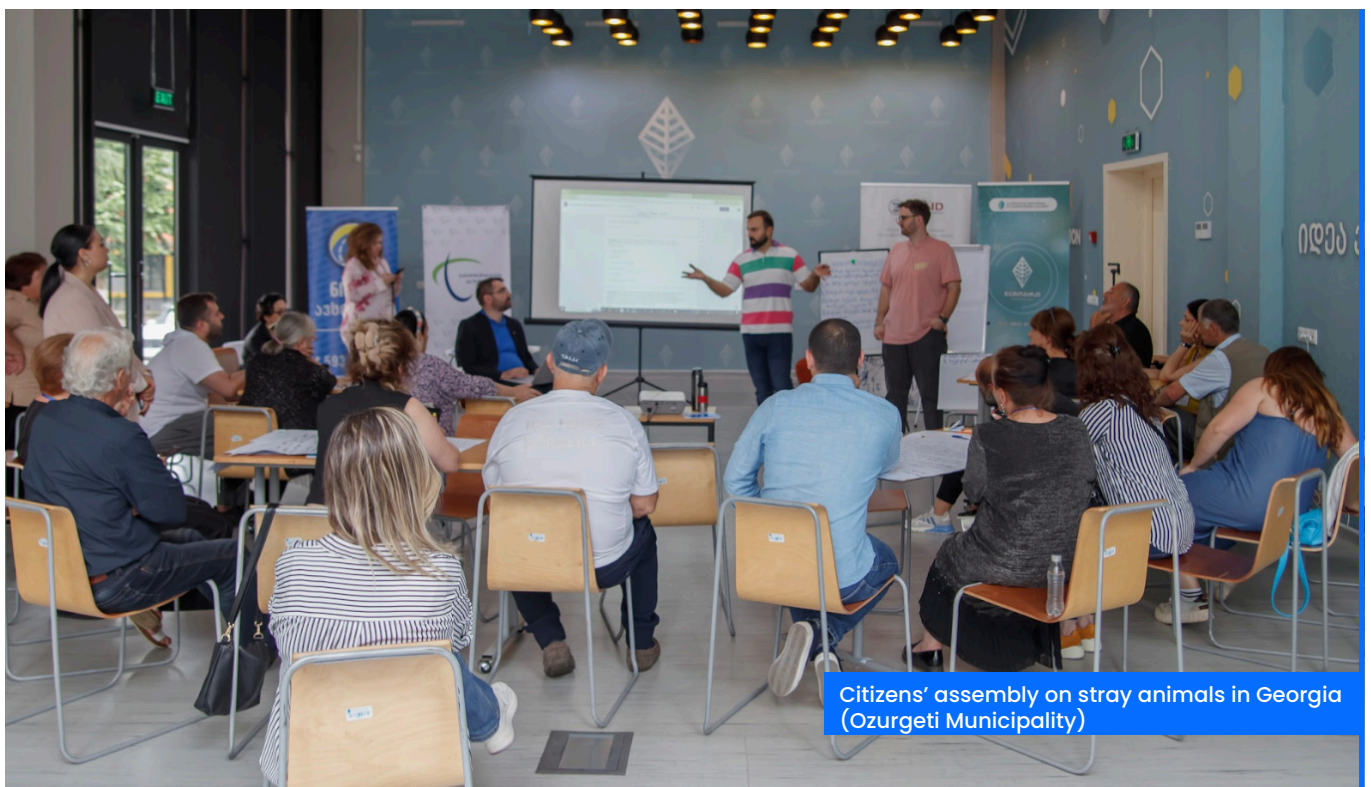


Finding 8: CAs foster a sense of community and social cohesion

- **France, the United States, Canada and the Netherlands:** CA participants reported strong bonds with each other and an increased feeling that they were part of a shared democratic effort. (Mellier & Tilikete 2025; Ehsassi 2023; Fournier et al. 2011)
- **Gdańsk (Poland):** CAs were effective at bringing citizens and governments closer together. (Ross 2022)
- **Mostar (Bosnia):** In divided or post-conflict settings assemblies were helpful in rebuilding trust and cooperation across social lines. (Curato, Ross, Parry 2025)
- **Yukon (Canada):** 76% of survey respondents answered that a strong sense of community emerged throughout the assembly. (Hurner 2024)
- **Victoria-Saanich (Canada):** Participants reported an increase from 75% to 82% in the belief that dialogue on public issues can strengthen social cohesion. (Brackenbury 2025)
- **Mar del Plata (Argentina):** Participants stayed in contact after the conclusion of a local CA and self-organized community actions such as beach clean-ups. (Annunziata 2025)

Practical Recommendations

- 🔗 **Planning & Design:**
 - Build in social time and rituals, such as shared meals, teambuilding activities, or daily closing ceremony, to strengthen group bonds.
- 🔍 **Research, Monitoring & Evaluation:**
 - Study how long these community effects last and whether they extend beyond the group itself.



Citizens' assembly on stray animals in Georgia (Ozurgeti Municipality)

Impacts on Communities



Finding 9: CAs promote dialogue across divides

- **United States:** Among participants in a national field experiment simulating a CA, those who initially took the strongest positions either in support or opposition on 26 policy issues moved closer together on all issues after hearing the perspectives of those who held the opposite views. (Fishkin et al. 2021)
- **Korsholm (Finland):** After reading statements produced by CA participants, community members reported being more likely to consider opposite perspectives on policy issues. (Setälä et al. 2020)
- **Connecticut (USA):** Participation in a simulated CA found that the deliberation brought people closer together on most policy preferences. (Farrar et al. 2010)
- **Turku (Finland):** Experimental CAs that intentionally mixed groups with high levels of disagreement on policy issues, found that participants valued the opportunity for deliberation even under these conditions and signaled an increased willingness to engage in future dialogue with those who held opposing views. (Grönlund et al. 2021)
- **Scotland:** about 85% of participants in a national climate assembly reported feeling both respected and listened to by their fellow participants even when they disagreed on issues, which gave hope for finding common ground more broadly.



Advocacy:

- Highlight success stories to inspire replication in divided societies.



Planning & Design:

- Use structured dialogue techniques and ensure ideological diversity in recruitment.



Research, Monitoring & Evaluation:

- Compare outcomes of CAs in high- vs. low-polarization environments.



Impacts on Communities



Finding 10: CAs influence broader public attitudes and discourse

- **Edmonton (Canada) and Oregon (USA):** Survey experiments found that when people learn about CAs they become more confident expressing their own policy opinions and sometimes shift their views closer to the assembly's conclusions. (Boulianne 2018b; Ingham & Levin 2017)
- **Korsholm (Finland) and Oregon (USA):** Members of the public who read a summary of the CA process and findings expressed more positive political attitudes and increased confidence in their own abilities to affect political change. (Setälä et al. 2020; Knobloch, Gastil, & Barthel 2019)
- **Poland, Ireland, Italy, Germany, and France:** Survey experiments found that when climate change skeptics were informed of a representative climate assembly's recommendations, there was a small but statistically significant increase in their willingness to believe that the proposed climate policies were warranted and potentially effective (Suiter, Saude, and McNally 2025).
- A meta-analysis of the literature concludes that CAs consistently encourage wider public discussion and engagement, helping people see democratic decision-making as something they can take part in, not just observe. (van der Does & Jacquet 2021)

Practical Recommendations

Advocacy:

- Publicize CA outputs widely through media, schools, and civic organizations.

Planning & Design:

- Produce accessible summaries and videos of deliberations and the CA's recommendations.

Research, Monitoring & Evaluation:

- Analyzing the relationship between broadcast and social media coverage of CAs is important to understanding their impact on public discourse.

Finding 11: CAs serve as trusted information proxies

- **Korsholm (Finland):** Voters who read a CA's statement during a local referendum found it useful and trustworthy, ranking it just behind independent experts and ahead of the media or government officials. (Setälä et al. 2020)
- **Germany:** Survey experiments found that policies proposed by a CA usually get more public support than those coming from the government. (Kuntze & Fesenfeld 2021)
- **British Columbia (Canada) and Oregon (USA):** CAs were perceived as trusted guides, which helped citizens make sense of complicated topics with fair and balanced information (Warren & Gastil 2015).

Planning & Design:

- Ensure transparency in expert selection and information vetting.

Research, Monitoring & Evaluation:

- Explore how trust in CAs compares to other institutions across contexts.

Impacts on Communities



Finding 12: CAs appeal to disaffected citizens, especially if they are representative and use random selection

- **15 Western European countries:** A survey experiment found the highest levels of support for decisional CAs among citizens who were most politically dissatisfied with the status quo. (Pilet et al. 2022)
- **Belgium:** Survey experiments found that citizens who expressed high levels of political dissatisfaction, political empowerment, or both were most supportive of decisional and consultative CAs. (Bedock & Pilet 2020)
- **Luxembourg:** Two survey experiments found that when citizens who were initially skeptical about CAs were informed that the composition was fair (representative), they became more positive and willing to accept policy recommendations, while learning that some groups were over- or under-represented worsened attitudes towards CAs. (Paulis et al. 2024)
- **Northern Ireland:** A survey experiment found the highest levels of perceived legitimacy and favorability for CAs that used random selection as opposed to elections, this remained true both for citizen only assemblies and those that mixed politicians and citizens. (Pow 2021)
- **Scotland and the United Kingdom:** Survey experiments found that one of the most politically disengaged demographics, young people, were most supportive of CAs as a means of identifying novel policy solutions on a complex challenge like climate change. (Elstub et al. 2025)
- A game theoretic analysis concluded that CAs are likely to be most impactful when they empower historically marginalized voices by slightly overrepresenting those groups in the composition of CAs. (Belova & Bardhi 2023)

Advocacy:

- Emphasize that CAs can be used to reinvigorate support for and engagement with democracy, especially among marginalized, disempowered, and disaffected groups.

Planning & Design:

- The public is most likely to support CAs that are representative of the population and which use random selection methods.



Impacts on Governments



Finding 13: CAs provide legitimacy and a public mandate for difficult decisions

- **United Kingdom:** Studies of several climate CAs show that policymakers and stakeholders view these processes as a way to move beyond short electoral cycles and gain public legitimacy for ambitious climate decisions, even when assemblies have limited direct policy impact. (Sandover, Moseley, & Devine-Wright 2021; Wells, Howarth, & Brand-Correa 2021)
- **Ireland:** Citizens perceived decisions as fairer and were more willing to accept an unpopular outcome when a CA was involved in the process, particularly among those with low political trust. (Germann, Muradova, & Marien 2024)
- **Belgium:** Interviews with politicians found they had supported institutionalizing CAs to share responsibility, rebuild trust in government, and use them to legitimize action in politically sensitive areas. (Sautter & Reuchamps 2022)

Practical Recommendations

Advocacy:

- Encourage policymakers to use CAs to build legitimacy on contentious issues.

Planning & Design:

- Align CA timing with the legislative decision-making windows to ensure clear links to existing policy processes.

Finding 14: CAs influence policymaking culture and institutional openness

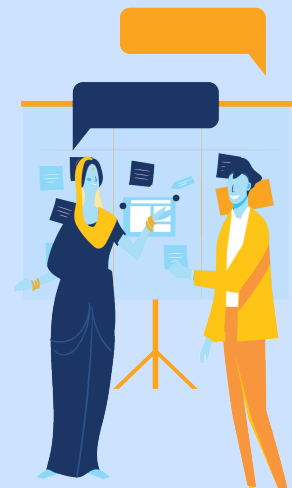
- **Canada:** A CA on medical policy helped officials see the value of being more transparent and listening to a wider range of voices. (Jones & Einsiedel 2011)
- **France:** A national Climate Assembly opened up previously closed political spaces, forcing lobby groups and policymakers to engage with citizen proposals and showing new ways for the public to take part in debates. (Mellier & Tilikete 2025)
- **Belgium:** Using CAs in the decision-making process on education reform challenged old hierarchies and made established actors like unions rethink how they share power. (Vrydagh, Reuchamps, & Devillers 2020)
- **Budapest (Hungary) and Poznań (Poland):** Public officials and NGOs learned from each other: officials saw assemblies as useful for solving problems, while NGOs saw them as a chance to hold government to account. (Pospieszna et al. 2025)
- **Gdańsk (Poland):** Assemblies helped public servants become more open to citizen input and set new standards for fair participation. (Ross 2022)

Advocacy:

- Frame CAs as tools for modernizing governance and improving responsiveness.

Planning & Design:

- Involve civil servants early and provide training on deliberative engagement.



Impacts on Governments



Finding 15: CAs can educate policymakers and even shift their policy preferences by introducing new perspectives

- **United Kingdom:** Officials saw assemblies as a chance to learn about public views and policy impacts they might have missed. (Wells, Howarth, & Brand-Correa 2021)
- **Petaluma, California (USA):** Officials developed a deeper respect for residents' ideas. (Ehsassi 2023)
- **Turku (Finland):** Politicians reported feeling that they had learned new things and gained valuable insights from the contributions of citizens in an assembly. (Grönlund et al. 2022)
- **Hungary, Poland, and Belgium:** Assemblies helped officials and politicians see issues through citizens' eyes, exchange expertise, and grow more open to collaboration. (Pospieszna et al. 2025; Ross 2022; Sautter & Reuchamps 2022)

Practical Recommendations

Planning & Design:

- Where possible, include structured interactions between citizens and officials.

Research, Monitoring & Evaluation:

- Study how exposure to citizen reasoning affects elite attitudes and decisions.



Finding 16: CAs can bypass institutional inaction and catalyze local action

- **Brazil:** When national climate policy stalled, several municipalities launched their own assemblies empowering local communities to act when higher levels of government would not. (Cervellini et al. 2024)
- **Turku (Finland):** Politicians reported learning from CA participants and co-developing novel policy solutions that elected officials would be unlikely to devise on their own. (Grönlund et al. 2022)
- **Devon (UK):** Local political leaders were able to leverage a CA to pressure the central government into providing more resources and granting more local autonomy to support the assembly's recommended actions (Moseley, Sandover, & Devine-Wright 2025)

Advocacy:

- Promote CAs as tools for local innovation when national systems stall.

Advocacy:

- Consider how political actors will interact with a CA process given their interests and the political context (Pfeffer & Newig 2025)

Impacts on Governments



Finding 17: CAs may face resistance from some politicians and stakeholders

- **Belgium:** Unions and experts worried that assemblies related to education reform would dilute their influence and questioned citizens' legitimacy in the policymaking process. (Vrydagh, Reuchamps, & Devillers 2020)
- **Poznań (Poland) and Budapest (Hungary):** Some officials saw assemblies as challenges to their authority, even as they acknowledged their value for generating solutions. (Pospieszna et al. 2025)
- **UN Member States:** According to elite interviews most UN member states remain wary of giving non-state actors a policymaking role via CAs. (Machani 2024)
- **Australia:** Surveys of federal politicians on attitudes toward CAs show that a majority (64%) doubt citizens' capacity to handle complex issues or produce truly representative outcomes. (Carson & Schechter 2019)
- **France, Germany, Ireland, Italy, and Poland:** Survey experiments found that politicians express higher support for and willingness to fund CAs if they are more representative and include some politicians as participants. (Ramis-Moyano, Pasadas-del-Amo, & Lancha-Hernández 2025)

Practical Recommendations

📣 Advocacy:

- Established politicians may view CAs as threats to their authority. Focus on the ways CAs can help them politically and consider including representatives in the CA.

🎯 Planning & Design:

- Involve skeptical actors in design and oversight roles, or where appropriate as participants in the CA, to build buy-in.

Finding 18: CAs are more likely to be adopted in reform-minded, resource-rich contexts

- **Switzerland:** Municipalities that adopted CAs tended to have professional, innovative administrators, strong local networks, and sufficient funding to organize such processes rather than doing so in response to legitimacy crises or low voter turnout. (Kübler et al. 2019).
- **OECD Countries:** Among OECD countries, assemblies have been most frequently initiated by Social-Democratic governments, which are generally more open to participatory reforms and experimentation. (Ramis-Moyano et al. 2025)
- **Devon (UK):** Interviews with politicians found that they regarded resource constraints as the biggest barrier to implementing CAs and realizing their policy impacts. (Moseley, Sandover, & Devine-Wright 2025)

🎯 Planning & Design:

- Align mandates of CAs with existing policy priorities and including policymakers in the process to help ensure that recommendations are implemented (Lancha-Hernández & Becerril-Viera 2025)

🔍 Research, Monitoring & Evaluation:

- Identify enabling conditions and pathways for adoption in less favorable contexts.

Impacts on Governments



Finding 19: CAs reshape traditional lobbying and advocacy dynamics

- **France:** A national Climate Assembly forced lobbyists to adapt to a more open process and gave social movements new ways to engage with institutions. (Mellier & Tilikete 2025)
- **Germany:** CAs that involved knowledge exchanges between scientists and citizens helped empower citizens to advocate for climate policies. (Blum, Wasin, & Kanang 2024)
- **Belgium:** Assemblies challenged unions and experts used to controlling the policymaking process. (Vrydagh, Reuchamps, & Devillers 2020)

Practical Recommendations

Advocacy:

- Frame CAs as an opportunity to make political decision-making more inclusive and equitable.



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